
PTI

recruits them after an elaborate filtering process, and they are invariably those already empanelled by other government agencies. For instance, the printers for examination papers are also empanelled by the RBI. However, the gaps emerge in the affiliated service providers the agencies hire. The driver of the vehicle carrying the paper is approved, but his assistant, or the loader, can be compromised. In 2024, the paper had to be transported to 4,750 centres.

Another place where the leaks can take place is the examination centre. A third-party review, conducted on the day NEET was held this year, found some worrying non-compliances at several centres. Of the 399 exam centres audited, 186 did not have the mandated two working CCTV cameras in each exam room. The live feed from these cameras is transmitted to the Central Control Room at the NTA headquarters in New Delhi, and should be monitored by a team of experts. At 68 exam centres, the strongroom was not "secured by a guard". At 83 centres, the biometric staff was not the same as the designated staff meant for the respective centres.

Beyond the logistical discrepancies, NTA insiders now claim that the postponement of several examinations was also triggered by the apprehension that the agency's security protocols may have been severely compromised and exposed to hackers. An organised cyber attack has been suspected and even the "black box", where question papers are centrally kept, may have been accessed. So, more leaks may take place unless the existing systems are secured.

Not only does the manpower at the NTA have to be beefed up, the agency must also be given constitutional status so that it can exert more authority

WHY THE SWITCH TO NEET

Before the NTA, it was the CBSE that conducted medical and engineering entrance examinations in India. Called the All India Pre-Medical/ Pre-Dental Entrance Test in its earlier avatar, the national-level common medical entrance exam existed alongside multiple other medical entrance exams conducted by respective states. A student clearing AIPMT could take direct admission into medical colleges under the central government and also avail the 15 per quota for non-resident students in every state medical college.

Over time, the system came to be characterised by several discrepancies, to rectify which NEET was envisioned. It had a three-pronged agenda: standardise the educational competence of students at the entry level as there was a noticeable disparity in the foundational knowledge of basic sciences such as Chemistry, Physics and Biology among students from different educational boards, reduce the number of entrance exams from an estimated 46 to one and eliminate the capitation fees levied by private medical colleges by reducing their discretion and granting admissions based on scores. By having one common entrance examination, the government hoped to streamline the process, making it more efficient and less cumbersome for all stakeholders involved.

Many, however, saw in it an undermining of India's federal structure. Tamil Nadu persistently opposed NEET, favouring its state policy of basing medical college admissions on high school performance. An expert committee led by Justice A.K. Rajan found that rural students and those from Tamil-medium schools faced a disproportionate disadvantage in NEET. From 2017 to 2021, the admission rate of Tamil-medium students in medical colleges plummeted from 15 per cent to a mere 1.6 per cent, while rural student admissions fell from 62 per cent to 50 per cent. Tamil Nadu saw this as significantly affecting its public health system, which depends on rural students to staff primary health centres. Pradhan, though, dismisses the criticism, pointing out how the NEET topper in 2023 was a girl from a Tamil Nadu village who had studied under the state board.

A return to the state-level entrance examinations or the abolition of NTA, as many are demanding, is unlikely to solve the problem. There were irregularities in earlier entrance exams too, including the JEE and AIPMT, CLAT and the National Law Aptitude Test (NLAT). Papers are leaked in state board examinations almost every year across India.

Several state governments have enacted strict laws against those found guilty of paper leaks and cheating, but to no avail. The central government recently passed The Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Act, 2024, which listed 15 actions, including leakage of question papers